

A50 817MQB (first prize), an HP Officejet 4255 (second prize), and a World Space Radio (third prize).

There are no restrictions on what problems contestants need to crack. Programmers can choose to build a Linux and/or Web Services application in the area of their interest and competence. There will be prominent display for the winners on the ZDNet India Web site.

While the contest opened online on October 20, the last date for submission of entries is December 20.

The winners will be announced on January 5, 2005. For more information and registration details, visit www.zdnetindia.com/devcontest/

GERMAN INNOVATION

Electronic Underwear And Heart Attacks

We've already seen devices that tell people when they are about to have a heart attack. These include mobile phones that you hold in front of your heart; and portable electrocardiograms, that require electrodes covered with gel stuck to the wearer's skin.



Now comes a German invention that removes the inconvenience those devices pose: electronic underwear that can detect imminent heart problems. The underwear is sensitive to fluctuations in the

wearer's heart rate. It has been developed by the Philips Research facility in Aachen.

The garment can automatically call emergency services when, for example, the wearer suffers a cardiac arrest. So how does it work? Sensors are woven into the fabric of the garment. These detect electrical fluctuations on the skin surface, which can tell how rapidly and how hard the wearer's heart is beating. Not only that, the garment also records activity and stress levels, which are important predictive factors in determining someone's risk of a heart attack.

The underwear concept is fantastic, because it is not only convenient—it is also an elegant solution. Heart-rate fluctuation detectors need to be in contact with the skin, and underwear always is. Besides, this way, the patient does not need to wear or hold anything that does not integrate with his lifestyle.

There is one hurdle to be overcome, however—there needs to be software that enables the device to distinguish between heart-rate fluctuations due to an impending attack, and fluctuations due to normal stress or physical activity.

INTERNET DOMINANCE

Of Google, Microsoft, Browsers And OSes

The idea of the Internet as an operating system was at first hyped; it then languished due to absence of real solutions and is now making a repeat appearance, somewhat shyly. The thinking was that one would log onto an online software, use it to do a task, and then log back out. Why should a user bother about patches and other associated headaches?

The idea is back. The Internet, now more than ever, is being touted as a platform for software deployment, and an increasing number of developers are building Web applications using markup languages such as XUL and XAML.

Some companies such as Google are banking on the idea, whereas others, such as Microsoft, would have things play out otherwise.

For Microsoft, Windows brings home the money; losing control of that platform is unthinkable, the kind of unthinkable which would have developers program for a browser rather than the operating system. After all, a browser isn't exactly locked onto a Windows platform... for a Google, a browser hosts ads and the more ubiquitous Internet browser, the more places the company can place its ads and thus gain revenue.

So while a Google looks to bring the Internet to the OS—Google has several software such as Gmail, Google Desktop, Picasa, Hello which integrate online with offline, apart from a rumoured Web browser that is in the making.

Microsoft hopes to keep developers, and hence users, pinned to Windows.

GENDER



BENDERS

Abhishek Chintakindi vs Prajakta Korde Download the Sasser Patch from Microsoft's Web site



Abhishek Chintakindi, a second-year Computer Engineering student, sat down apprehensively at the monitor. Once at the Microsoft site, he wasn't quite sure where to look. Should I look under downloads? Probably search it off? Nearly seven minutes and no sign of the patch. A little change in the search string did the trick and a relieved Abhishek was all smiles as he downloaded the removal tool.



Prajakta Korde, also a second-year Computer Engineering student, was confidence personified as she took her seat. "The Sasser Removal tool, right?", she asked to confirm whether she heard it correctly. And then she was at it in full gusto. A minute passed as she made her way to the Downloads section. But look, there it is under 'Most Popular Downloads'. A quick click on the link and Prajakta had the download done.